

Customer Service and Logistics Playbook 2026

Order promise management, fulfillment quality, support triage, and service recovery policies

NWT-OPS-2026-KB-03 | Knowledge Base Edition | Effective 2026-02-01
Owner: Operations, Logistics, and Customer Success

Document purpose	This reference gives an AI knowledge base realistic business context about Northwind Traders decisions, policies, metrics, and operating language.
How to use	Use this document to answer questions, classify intent, retrieve policy details, summarize tradeoffs, and generate grounded recommendations.
Keywords	logistics, customer service, SLA, stock-out, substitutions, credits, fulfillment, Northwind
Scope note	Scenario-based internal reference. The content is self-contained and does not depend on database schemas or raw exports.

Confidentiality: Internal training and knowledge-base reference. Do not distribute outside approved demo or analysis environments.

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Section	What it answers in a knowledge base
1. Operating model and service principles	Defines how Northwind fulfills, communicates, and protects customer trust.
2. Service-level targets and customer tiers	Maps customer tier to delivery, response, and escalation expectations.
3. Order intake and promise management	Explains order cutoffs, substitutions, partials, and promise governance.
4. Inventory allocation and stock-out handling	Defines allocation priorities and proactive customer actions.
5. Fulfillment quality and carrier selection	Covers pick/pack controls, handoff rules, and carrier routing logic.
6. Customer support triage	Defines issue classification, SLAs, owners, and resolution standards.
7. Returns, credits, and service recovery	Provides credit rules, evidence requirements, and recovery gestures.
8. Communication templates and tone	Gives ready-to-use customer message patterns.
9. Metrics and continuous improvement	Lists operational KPIs, targets, and action thresholds.
10. FAQ and glossary	Answers common logistics and support-policy questions.

Retrieval guidance: queries with terms like "policy", "threshold", "target", "owner", "exception", "scorecard", and "escalation" should use the relevant section headers and table labels as anchors.

Document Control and Knowledge Base Metadata

Document ID	NWT-OPS-2026-KB-03	Owner	Operations, Logistics, and Customer Success
Version	v1.0 - 2026 operating playbook	Effective date	2026-02-01
Status	Approved for KB pilot	Primary audience	Sales, Operations, Customer Success, Data/AI teams
Retrieval keywords	logistics, customer service, SLA, stock-out, substitutions, credits, fulfillment, Northwind	Use in KB	Grounding, policy lookup, examples, RAG test cases

Canonical interpretation rules

- When customer tier and incident severity conflict, follow the stricter response standard.
- When a sales promise differs from operational capacity, the operationally validated promise is controlling until an exception is approved.
- When a response involves credit, confirm evidence, customer tier, incident class, and financial approval threshold.
- For perishable or high-risk goods, quality hold and customer transparency take priority over speed of dispatch.

KB ingestion notes

Chunking anchor	Policy name + trigger + SLA	Keep each issue class, response time, and owner in the same chunk.
High-value entities	Customer tier, SLA, stock-out, substitution, credit, carrier	Use aliases like priority account, late delivery, damaged goods, partial shipment.
Answer style	Status + customer action + internal owner	Operational answers should include what happened, what to say, and who acts.
Risk flags	Priority account, late delivery, safety/quality hold, high-value credit	Escalate where service recovery or QA containment may be needed.

1. Operating Model and Service Principles

Northwind Traders operates a service model built around reliability, transparency, and controlled complexity. The company does not promise every product to every customer on every lane. It promises what can be fulfilled with quality, documented handling, and credible communication.

The 2026 operations playbook supports sales growth by defining how orders are promised, allocated, picked, shipped, and recovered when something goes wrong. It is intended for customer service, logistics, warehouse operations, sales, and AI knowledge-base use cases.

Principle	Operational meaning	Customer-facing behavior
Promise what is validated	Do not create custom delivery or handling commitments without lane and capacity validation.	Give a realistic date rather than an optimistic date.
Protect quality first	Hold goods when safety, traceability, or temperature evidence is incomplete.	Explain that the hold protects product integrity.
Communicate before the customer asks	Notify priority accounts about delays, substitutions, or partials as soon as risk is known.	Use proactive ETA and recovery options.
Resolve root causes	A credit closes the financial issue, not the operational issue.	Share what changed after repeated failures.

Default operations standard: accuracy and trust beat speed when a shipment involves quality risk, customer event risk, or priority-account disruption.

2. Service-Level Targets and Customer Tiers

Customer tiers define response urgency, not customer worth. Every customer receives accurate service. Priority tiers receive faster escalation because a disruption may affect strategic retention, regional influence, or recurring revenue.

Customer tier	Definition	Order promise standard	Support response target	Escalation rule
Tier 1 - Priority managed	Strategic, high revenue, or executive-designated account	Validated delivery window and proactive exception alerts	Same business day; urgent issues within 2 hours	Escalate late, damaged, or incomplete order same day
Tier 2 - Managed	Recurring account with assigned owner and service expectations	Standard lane promise with documented substitutions	Within 1 business day	Escalate repeated issue or event risk
Tier 3 - Standard	Active customer without custom service commitment	Published cutoff and standard delivery estimate	Within 2 business days	Escalate safety, quality, or payment dispute
Tier 4 - Transactional	Occasional buyer or trial account	Available service only; no custom promise	Within 3 business days	Escalate only critical quality or compliance issues

SLA interpretation

- Urgent support means order cannot be used for a scheduled customer event, menu service, retail promotion, or contract commitment.
- A Tier 1 issue does not always justify a credit, but it always justifies rapid communication and ownership.
- Tier changes must be approved by Sales Operations and Customer Success; individual reps cannot unilaterally assign priority status.

3. Order Intake and Promise Management

Promise management begins before the order is accepted. Customer service must confirm cutoff, availability, lane capacity, handling requirements, and substitution preferences for managed accounts.

Order scenario	Accept rule	Promise rule	Customer communication
Standard in-stock order before cutoff	Accept normally	Use published lane promise	Confirm order and estimated ship/delivery window
Order after cutoff	Accept if capacity exists or schedule next cycle	Do not backdate promise	State next available dispatch window
Partial availability	Confirm customer preference before shipping partial for managed accounts	Promise available lines only	Offer partial shipment, substitute, or hold for complete order
Unvalidated cold-chain lane	Do not accept custom date without logistics validation	Promise only after QA/logistics check	Explain validation protects product integrity
Event-critical order	Flag as urgent and verify feasibility	Use confirmed ETA, not standard estimate	Provide backup option and escalation contact

No silent substitutions: if an item has allergen, spec, menu, or retail shelf impact, customer approval is required before substitution.

4. Inventory Allocation and Stock-Out Handling

Inventory allocation protects revenue, customer trust, and service commitments when supply is constrained. Allocation should be transparent, documented, and aligned to customer tier and operational feasibility.

Allocation priority	Who qualifies	Allocation action	Communication rule
1. Safety or quality hold	All customers affected by held lots	Block release until QA decision	Explain product integrity hold; do not promise release time prematurely
2. Event-critical Tier 1 order	Priority account with documented event date or service commitment	Reserve available compliant stock if feasible	Same-day update and backup option
3. Recurring managed replenishment	Tier 1 or Tier 2 customers with forecasted recurring demand	Allocate based on committed cadence and order history	Notify early if allocation will be short
4. Campaign commitments	Customers tied to approved campaign supply plan	Allocate within campaign reserve rules	Offer alternate SKU if reserve depleted
5. Transactional or spot orders	Non-recurring demand	Fulfill from remaining available stock	Provide next availability or alternative

Stock-out response ladder

- Confirm whether the item is truly unavailable or only unavailable on the requested lane/date.
- Check pre-approved substitutes and customer-specific restrictions.
- Offer split shipment only when freight and customer impact are acceptable.
- Record lost demand reason so planning can distinguish supply constraint from customer choice.

5. Fulfillment Quality and Carrier Selection

Fulfillment quality is measured by whether the customer receives the correct goods, in usable condition, with the documentation and timing needed to serve their own customers. Carrier selection is therefore a quality decision, not only a cost decision.

Fulfillment control	Required action	Applies to	Owner
Pick accuracy check	Scan item, lot, and quantity against order before pack close	All orders	Warehouse Operations
Cold-chain handoff	Verify packaging, temperature evidence, and carrier lane suitability	Chilled, frozen, and sensitive goods	Warehouse QA + Logistics
Retail presentation protection	Use carton and dunnage standards for shelf-facing packs	Confections, premium beverages, giftable items	Packaging Lead
Document pack	Attach COA or customer-required docs when order profile requires it	Managed accounts and regulated categories	Customer Service
Carrier exception review	Review carrier performance before assigning high-risk lanes	Tier 1, event-critical, cold-chain orders	Logistics Manager

Carrier choice factor	Use low-cost carrier when...	Use premium/validated carrier when...
Customer tier	Standard account and no special risk	Priority account, event critical, or repeated issue history
Product sensitivity	Shelf-stable, low damage risk	Cold-chain, fragile, retail presentation, or high-value goods
Lane performance	On-time and damage trend is stable	Lane is new, disrupted, or below target performance

6. Customer Support Triage and Ownership

Support triage assigns a class, response target, internal owner, and expected resolution path. The customer should never need to know Northwind internal handoffs; the support owner coordinates internally and communicates externally.

Issue class	Examples	First response target	Primary owner	Resolution standard
Urgent service disruption	Late Tier 1 event order, unusable shipment, missing event-critical item	2 hours	Customer Success	ETA/recovery option same day; root cause opened
Quality or safety concern	Temperature issue, damaged perishables, suspected contamination, allergen question	Same business day	Quality Assurance	Contain product; do not advise use until QA decision
Order accuracy issue	Wrong item, quantity mismatch, missing line	1 business day	Customer Service	Correct, replace, credit, or explain approved substitution
Billing or credit question	Invoice mismatch, credit delay, pricing dispute	2 business days	Billing Support	Reconcile against order, approval, and credit policy
General inquiry	Availability, lead time, product documentation request	2 business days	Customer Service	Answer or route with expected follow-up date

Support ownership rule: one visible owner remains accountable to the customer even when QA, logistics, billing, or sales must contribute to the solution.

7. Returns, Credits, and Service Recovery

Credits and returns should restore fairness without hiding root causes. A credit may be appropriate even when replacement is impossible, but repeated credits without operational correction signal unresolved service failure.

Scenario	Evidence required	Default remedy	Approval threshold	Notes
Damaged shelf-stable goods	Photo, order number, item/lot if available	Replace or credit affected quantity	Manager above 500 EUR	Check packaging or carrier trend
Perishable quality concern	Photo, temperature info if relevant, arrival time	QA review before credit or disposal guidance	QA required for release/use guidance	Customer should not use product until advised
Late delivery	Promised window, actual delivery time, customer impact	Service credit if commitment missed and impact documented	Manager above 250 EUR	No credit for standard estimate unless commitment existed
Wrong item or quantity	Order record, pick record, customer report	Replacement, corrected shipment, or credit	Manager above 500 EUR	Capture root cause: pick, master data, substitute approval
Customer ordering error	Order confirmation and customer request history	Return if resaleable and allowed; restocking may apply	Manager for waiver	Do not credit perishable goods if resale is not possible

Service recovery ladder

- Acknowledge the disruption and confirm the facts.
- Offer the fastest feasible remedy: replacement, substitute, partial shipment, credit, or future order adjustment.
- For priority accounts, schedule a brief recovery review after repeated issues.

8. Communication Templates and Tone

Customer communication should be direct, specific, and accountable. Avoid vague language such as "system issue" or "logistics delay" without a next action. The best message explains what is known, what Northwind is doing, and when the customer will hear next.

Situation	Recommended wording pattern
Delay discovered before dispatch	We identified a delay before dispatch on your order [order reference]. The earliest validated dispatch window is [date/time]. We can either ship available lines now, hold for a complete order, or review approved substitutes.
Quality hold	We have placed [item/lot/order] on quality hold while we verify product integrity. We will not release uncertain goods. We will update you by [time] with the release decision or replacement option.
Partial availability	Part of your order is available now. For the unavailable line, we can offer [substitute], ship the available items first, or hold the order until [date]. Please confirm your preference.
Service recovery after late order	We missed the agreed delivery window for [order]. We are correcting the immediate issue by [action] and have opened a root-cause review so this does not repeat.

Tone standards

- Use plain language and exact dates or windows whenever possible.
- Do not blame the customer, carrier, supplier, or another team in customer-facing messages.
- Do not promise compensation before confirming credit policy and approval threshold.

9. Metrics and Continuous Improvement

Operations metrics must be tied to improvement loops. A KPI should identify where to focus: pick process, inventory planning, supplier quality, carrier performance, customer communication, or sales promise discipline.

Metric	Definition	Target	Action threshold	Owner
Perfect order rate	Orders delivered complete, correct, on time, and without damage	92%+	Below 90% weekly triggers cross-functional review	Operations Director
On-time ship promise	Orders shipped within validated promise window	95%+	Below 93% pauses custom promises on affected lane	Logistics Manager
Pick accuracy	Lines picked without item, lot, or quantity error	99.3%+	Below 99% triggers warehouse quality audit	Warehouse Lead
Proactive exception notice	Priority-account exceptions communicated before customer inquiry	90%+	Below 85% triggers support workflow review	Customer Success
Credit reason recurrence	Repeat credits by reason and customer segment	Downward trend	Top 3 recurring reasons get corrective action	Customer Service Manager
Carrier damage trend	Damaged lines by carrier and lane	<0.5%	Above 1.0% requires routing review	Logistics Analyst

Continuous improvement rule: repeated credits for the same reason must create a corrective action, not just another refund.

10. FAQ and Glossary

Question	Canonical answer for KB
Can customer service promise an earlier delivery than the lane standard?	Only after logistics validates capacity and handling requirements. Do not promise unvalidated dates.
Can Northwind substitute an item without approval?	No silent substitutions for allergen, specification, menu, or retail shelf impact. Managed accounts require approval based on documented preferences.
What should happen when product is on quality hold?	Hold product, explain that the hold protects integrity, and provide the next update time or replacement path.
When is a credit appropriate for late delivery?	When a validated commitment was missed and customer impact is documented. Standard estimates do not automatically create credit entitlement.
Who owns the customer during a multi-team issue?	One support owner remains visible to the customer while coordinating QA, logistics, billing, sales, or warehouse internally.

Glossary

Term	Definition
Perfect order	An order that is complete, correct, on time, undamaged, and has the required documentation.
Validated promise	A service commitment confirmed against inventory, lane capacity, handling rules, and customer requirements.
Quality hold	A temporary block preventing release or use until product integrity or documentation is verified.
Service recovery	Customer-facing response that remedies the immediate issue and addresses the root cause.
Event-critical order	An order tied to a customer event, menu launch, promotion, or contractual commitment where failure has high impact.